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Grade	1	Word Count	296
Lexile	490L	Multi-level	J V Z1
Learning A–Z	level J		

Refer to the Focus Question on page 2 of this title to guide discussion and support additional learning connected to the text.

From its culture and celebrations to its various landforms and animal life, **Mexico** has many interesting things for students to learn about. Maps and photographs support the text.

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Mexico

Written by Taylor Campos

Mexico



Above: A quetzal nests in a tree in Mexico.

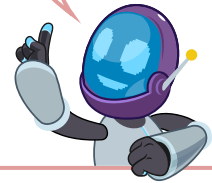
Cover: A Mexican dancer spins around in her traditional dress at a dance show.

Page 3: The ruins of the Maya can be seen near Palenque (pah-LEN-keh), a town in Mexico.

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Focus Question

What makes Mexico an interesting country?



Words to Know

cactus

deserts

canyons

fireworks

chile peppers

parades

Discussion Questions

Analyze

What kinds of foods might be in a meal in Mexico? Which foods would you like?

Evaluate

How are Mexican celebrations different from your own celebrations? How are they the same?



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Where Is It?

Mexico is a country in North America. To the north of it is the United States. To the south of it is Central America. To the east and west of Mexico is the sea.



Many cities in Mexico have old as well as new buildings.

More than 120 million people live in Mexico.

Most of them live in cities.



Mountains surround Mexico City. Two of the mountains are volcanoes.

The capital of Mexico is Mexico City.

It is one of the oldest cities in North America.

It also has more people than any other city in North America!



Some Native peoples in Mexico speak their own languages.

People

Most people in Mexico speak Spanish.

More people speak Spanish in Mexico than anywhere else.



Land

Mountains and **canyons** cover much of Mexico.

Dry **deserts** are in the north.

Forests cover land to the south.

Two pieces of land stretch into the ocean.

Baja (BAH-hah) is like a long finger.

Yucatán (yoo-kah-TAHN) is more like a thumb.



Mountain lions roam the deserts of Mexico.

Animals

Many different animals call Mexico home.

Parrots, frogs, and many other animals live in the hot, wet forests. Foxes, lizards, and other animals live in the hot, dry deserts.



Toys for the Day of the Dead are skulls and skeletons.

Celebrations

People in Mexico celebrate many special days.

The Day of the Dead lasts three days.

It is a happy time.

People remember their loved ones.

They light candles and wear masks.

People also remember the day long ago when Mexico began its fight to be free.
They dress up and walk in **parades**.
They light **fireworks** to celebrate.



Fireworks are part of Mexican Independence Day celebrations.



Mexicans use corn to make tortillas (tohr-TEE-uhz).

Food

Corn is an important food in Mexico.
It is in almost every meal.
People in Mexico also eat parts of **cactus**.
They eat chicken and pork.
Some people eat food from the sea.

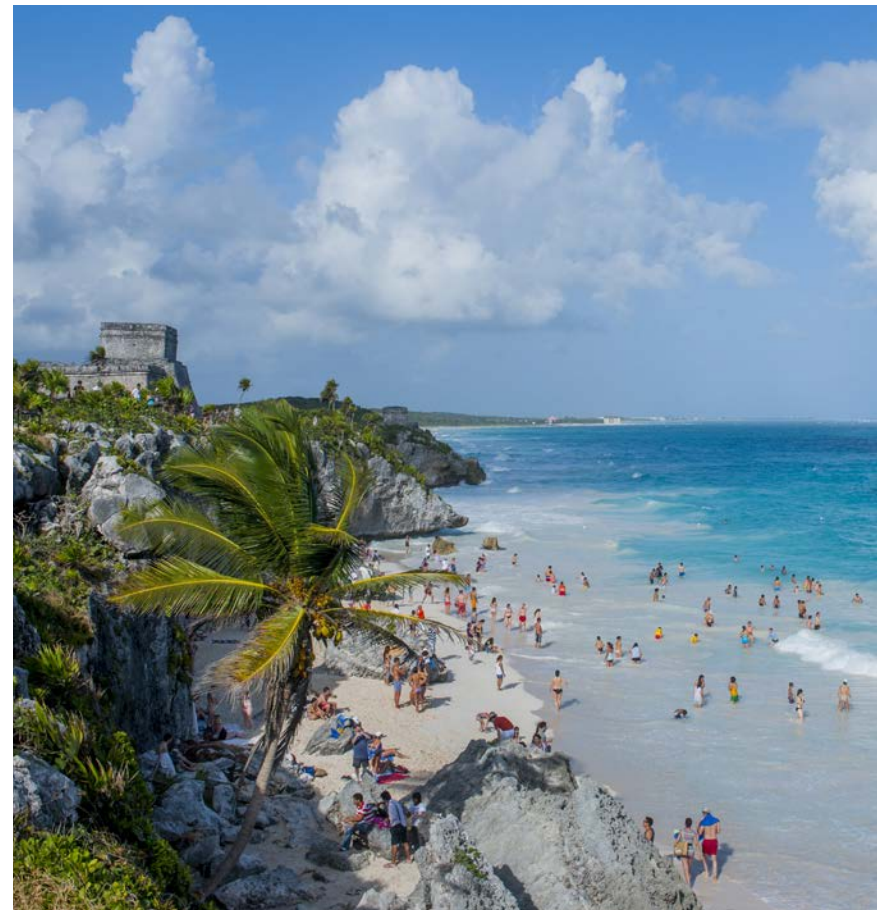
People in Mexico often use peppers in their food.

Some peppers are hot, like **chile** (CHIH-lee) **peppers**.

Some peppers just make food taste different.



Peppers are used in many Mexican dishes.



People from all over the world come to visit Mexico's beaches.

Conclusion

Mexico is an exciting country.

Many different people and animals live there.

What is your favorite thing about Mexico?



Population: 127,575,529

Land: 1,964,375 sq km (758,450 sq. mi.)

Capital City: Mexico City

Primary Language: Spanish

Currency: Peso (PAY-soh)



Source: Central Intelligence Agency (2019), World Bank

Glossary

cactus (*n.*) page 12

a desert plant that usually has spines instead of leaves

canyons (*n.*) page 8

deep valleys with steep sides that are usually formed by rivers

chile peppers (*n.*) page 13

the fruits of the pepper plant, which are often used to make spicy seasonings

deserts (*n.*) page 8

areas of land that do not usually get much rain

fireworks (*n.*) page 11

devices that produce light, sound, and smoke when lit, often used for celebrations

parades (*n.*) page 11

people or vehicles moving forward at a regular pace during celebrations or ceremonies